Counting AI Layoffs from the Employer's Own Words

Evidence from a source-cited register of 243 layoff events linked to artificial intelligence, 2023 to 2026

AI Layoffs (ailayoffs.org)

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This paper: doi:10.5281/zenodo.23148082 (licensed CC BY 4.0). Corrections: hello@ailayoffs.org.

ABSTRACT

Counts of layoffs attributed to artificial intelligence differ several-fold, mainly because they count different things. We assembled a register of 243 layoff events at 208 employers, dated May 2023 to September 2026, that employers, filings or credible reporting linked to AI, and recorded for each event who made the link and who stated the number of jobs. Every event links to a main source that is free to open. In 34 events (14%) the employer itself declared the cut AI-related; in 148 (61%) it cited AI alongside other material factors, such as cost or demand; in 61 (25%) only the press, analysts or other trackers made the link, and in 9 of those the employer denied it. We call a figure *counted* when the employer both named AI as a reason and stated the number, or a percentage of a headcount it publishes. Of the 358,974 jobs in all the figures the register records, 59,454 (17%) are counted, and none of the ten largest figures is. For January to September 2026 the register's worldwide total of reported figures is 186,347 jobs and its counted total 43,880; the widely cited count of Challenger, Gray & Christmas, 120,136 job cuts that US-based employers announced with AI as the reason, lies between them. Challenger's AI-cited count for January to August equals 0.8% of the layoffs and discharges US employers carried out in those months. In events where the employer named AI and the sources say which jobs went, software engineering and IT appear most often. The register and its rules are public and versioned.

Keywords: artificial intelligence; layoffs; job loss; technological unemployment; corporate disclosure; AI washing; labor statistics; open data

JEL: J23, J63, O33, M14

1. Introduction

In the first nine months of 2026, US employers announced 120,136 job cuts for which artificial intelligence was the stated reason, according to the outplacement firm Challenger, Gray & Christmas (Challenger, Gray & Christmas 2026). That is 2.2 times the total for all of 2025 and about a fifth (21%) of all the cuts it recorded. Studies of the labor market itself have found little sign of AI in the aggregates. The occupational mix of US employment shows no discernible disruption since ChatGPT's release (Gimbel et al. 2025). Danish administrative data show precise null effects on earnings and recorded hours (Humlum and Vestergaard 2025). Where an effect does appear, in US payroll data, it is a decline in the employment of young workers in AI-ex-

posed occupations, and it works mainly through reduced hiring rather than more separations (Brynjolfsson, Chandar and Chen 2026). Analysts have suggested that some firms "dress up layoffs as a good news story" (May and Badawy 2026), and executives surveyed in December 2025 described AI-related cuts made in anticipation of what AI will do rather than what it has done (Davenport and Srinivasan 2026).

These findings need not conflict, because a count of AI layoffs is a count of claims. A layoff enters the count when someone says AI caused it, and who says so matters. An employer that writes in its annual report that adopting AI has reduced its workforce makes a different claim from a newspaper that connects the same employer's cuts to its spending on AI. The number matters as well: a figure the employer states as a cut is not the same as a reporter's estimate, an upper limit ("up to") or the net change between two headcounts, which folds hiring, attrition and divestitures into one number.

Public counts rarely record, for each event, who made the claim about cause and who stated the number. Challenger codes the reason employers give for announced cuts but does not publish the events behind its totals. Trackers such as Layoffs.fyi (Layoffs.fyi 2026) list events and link to coverage, but as far as we know none records, event by event, whether the employer itself named AI and stated the number.

This paper describes a register built to record both, and reports what it shows. The AI Layoffs Register aims to record every layoff that an employer, a filing or credible reporting has linked to AI, including links the employer rejects, and classifies each one on two questions: did the employer itself name AI as a reason, and did the employer state the number of jobs? Every event links to a source anyone can open for free. Classification follows written rules, published with the data; changes are logged in a public corrections log; each version is archived with a DOI. The register measures attribution, meaning who said AI was a cause. It does not estimate how many jobs AI in fact eliminated, a question no statement can settle.

Four findings stand out.

- **AI is rarely presented as the sole reason for a cut.** In 34 of 243 events (14%) the employer declared the cut AI-related; in 148 (61%) it cited AI alongside other material factors, such as cost, demand or restructuring; in 61 (25%) the employer did not name AI as a reason. Employers declared the cut AI-related in 21% of 2025 events and 11% of 2026 events.
- **Most of the reported total comes from figures that fail on cause or on the number.** Of the 358,974 jobs in all reported figures, 59,454 (17%) are counted: they are in cuts where the employer both named AI as a reason and stated the number, or a percentage of a headcount it publishes. Of the 299,520 set aside, 60% come from cuts where the employer named no AI reason or denied the link to AI. None of the ten largest figures in the register, from 10,000 to 30,000 jobs each, is counted.
- **The counted total is small and concentrated.** Five events account for 40% of counted jobs, and the median counted figure is 262 jobs. Where employers declared a cut AI-related without citing other factors, the counted figures total 5,705 jobs, in 16 events.

- **The jobs named are mainly software, IT and office roles.** In events where the employer named AI and the sources say which jobs went, software engineering and IT appear in 61 of 127 events, operations and back-office work in 41, corporate functions in 37 and customer service in 32 (one event can name several kinds of job).

Section 2 explains how the register is built. Section 3 describes what it holds. Section 4 reports the findings, Section 5 discusses what they imply for reading AI layoff numbers, and Section 6 sets out the limitations. Section 7 describes how to obtain and cite the data.

2. How the register is built

2.1 What counts as an event

An event is either a specific employer's announced or reported job cut for which AI (artificial intelligence, generative AI, AI agents, or automation explicitly tied to AI) is named as a reason, by the employer or by credible reporting, or a *workforce statement*: an employer's public statement about AI and the size of its workforce when no discrete cut is announced. By our reading, 8 events are workforce statements, among them Amazon's June 2025 memo, JPMorgan Chase's 2025 projection for its operations staff and Klarna's 2025 statement that it would bring human customer-service agents back. None of them carries a counted figure. Events from any country are included. Tracking starts in May 2023, the month Challenger first recorded AI as a reason for US job cuts. Three things are excluded: a restructuring with no AI link anywhere, a story about an employer's AI investment that does not tie the investment to the cut, and automation that the employer does not tie to AI. One announcement is one event: when later reporting adds detail or a second source to the same cut, it is attached to the existing event, and a later running total that includes cuts already recorded is not recorded again. A layoff that others call an AI layoff is recorded, rather than dropped, even if the employer names another cause or denies the link, provided a source that anyone can open presents the cut itself as caused by AI. A tracker's label alone is not enough, nor is coverage that only mentions the employer's AI plans beside the cut. Recording these events lets a reader who meets the claim elsewhere check it here; a figure attached to one is never counted.

2.2 Sources

Each event cites one main source by name and URL, and every main source opens without a paywall; where a story first appeared behind one, the same facts were found on a free page (the employer's own release or filing, or another outlet), and the paywalled original appears at most as a corroborating link. The main sources of the 243 events come from 116 distinct domains; for 57 events the main source is a filing with the US Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC), and 231 events also list corroborating sources. Each event also carries an evidence tier, which grades how strongly its sources support the link to AI, as published in the register's methodology. Tier 1: the employer's own filing, on-record earnings call or official statement (107 events). Tier 2: credible journalism quoting a named company source (115). Tier 3: a single secondary source, an unnamed source or vague forward-looking language (21). Among the 182 events where the employer named AI, 99 are tier 1 and 83 tier 2; tier 3 appears only on events

where the employer did not name AI (blamed, Section 2.3), so its weight never applies to a counted figure. Quotations are copied from the source; a figure, date or quotation that could not be read on an opened page is not recorded.

2.3 Who named AI

Every event carries one of three attribution grades, as defined in the register's published methodology. **Explicit**: the employer itself declared the cut AI-related, without citing other material factors. **Mixed**: the employer cited AI alongside other material factors, such as cost, demand or restructuring. **Blamed**: the link to AI comes only from the press, analysts, other trackers or unnamed sources, and the employer named no AI reason or denied the link. The grades record what the employer said, not whether AI in fact caused the cut. Speech the press explicitly attributes to the employer ("the company said", "according to a spokesperson") counts as the employer's; a reporter's own sentence does not, nor does a paraphrase of the employer's reasons ("citing advances in AI") where the employer's own statement names no AI. A *denial* is a statement by the employer that AI was not a reason for the cut; for an employer that named no AI reason at all, a statement that AI did not replace the people cut is recorded as a denial too. When the employer's own statements conflict, a denial keeps the figure out of every counted total, even where another of its statements names AI; the event records both. A statement that AI is not doing the work of the people cut, made while the employer names AI as a reason (for example, freeing money to invest in AI), is not a denial.

2.4 Which numbers count

A figure is *counted* only when the employer named AI as a reason (explicit or mixed) and stated the number on the record: in a filing, a release or a letter it publishes, through a named executive speaking publicly, or through its spokesperson, including a number the press reports as the employer's own. Three further cases count: a point percentage the employer states, applied to the workforce it publishes (its most recent published headcount); a range the employer states, at its lower end; and a planned cut the employer states as a move from one headcount to another, at the difference. Together these conditions are the *figure rule*. Every other figure that reporting attached to the cut is kept as a *set-aside* figure, with the grounds for setting it aside. Cause grounds: the employer named no AI reason, or denied the link. Figure grounds: the number comes from the press rather than the employer (unnamed sources, an unconfirmed memo, a reporter's arithmetic), is an upper limit, is a net change between two headcounts published at different dates (which nets hiring, attrition and divestitures together), comes through attrition, or includes contractors or roles moved to other teams or places. Counted and set-aside figures together make up the *reported total*, one figure per event. Applying a stated percentage to a published headcount is how 16 counted figures, 3,991 jobs in all, were obtained; beyond that, no number is estimated or filled in: a percentage without a published base, a percentage given as a bound or as nearly a value, a vague quantity and a state layoff notice that covers only part of a cut are not converted into figures. The full rules are reproduced in Appendix B.

2.5 Plans, reversals and evidence weights

Each event also records whether the cut was carried out: executed (139 events), partly executed (26), planned (73), reversed (2) or unknown (3). For the AI Layoffs Index, which is built on the register, each counted figure is multiplied by three published weights: source tier (1 for tier 1, 0.8 for tier 2, 0.5 for tier 3), attribution (1 for explicit, 0.4 for mixed) and execution (1 for executed, 0.7 for partly executed, 0.7 for unknown, 0.5 for planned, 0.15 for reversed). The weights are judgments, not estimates; the register publishes them so that any reader can recompute the evidence-weighted totals or substitute their own.

2.6 Job families

To answer which jobs were cut, every event carries one or more of twelve job families, assigned by the register's editor from the functions the sources name: software engineering and IT; operations and back office; corporate functions; customer service and support; sales and marketing; product and design; management layers; writing, editorial and translation; content moderation; consulting and professional services; frontline and manual work; and "not specified" when the sources do not say which roles went. Labels were first proposed by keyword rules over the functions field (the roles each source names) and then reviewed event by event. The labels are published in the register's JSON interface and, for this version, as a supplementary file with this paper.

2.7 Checks, corrections and completeness

Every event has been re-read against its source, and every main source link has been checked. Automated integrity checks are run over the whole register when it changes: for example, a counted figure must carry an employer attribution, every figure set aside must carry its grounds, and a source on a paywalled domain is flagged. Changes that move a published number are summarized in a public corrections log. On October 3 and 4, 2026, the register was checked for completeness against public trackers (18 of the 21 checked could be opened) and news coverage. For January to August 2026 the check examined 84 layoffs that other trackers or the press listed as AI layoffs and the register lacked: 71 are now in the register, and 13 were left out, 9 because no source anyone could open presented the cut itself as caused by AI or because the event was not a job cut, and 4 because the coverage only mentioned the employer's AI plans beside the cut. A scan of news and filings from August 25 to October 3 added a further 13 events (12 announced in that window and one from May that surfaced with them), and the same completeness check applied to 2025 added 43 events and left out 8 leads. These checks took the register from 116 events to 242. Writing this paper, and independent checks of it against the data, then showed that some rules had been applied to the events each review reread but not to every event. Version 1.31, the version used here, corrects what those checks found. Among the changes: Amazon's October 2025 figure of about 14,000 is set aside because its chief executive said the round was not AI-driven; Klarna's December 2024 figure of 1,000 is set aside as a fall between two headcounts; BT's 2023 figure of 10,000 is set aside because BT states it as part of its total labour resource, which includes contractors; HP's stated plan to cut 4,000 to 6,000 is now counted at its lower end; stated point percentages are converted wherever

the employer publishes the headcount they apply to; figures that include work moving to other countries are set aside; and figures for 7 events that the register had left blank are now recorded as set aside. Firebolt's February 2026 cut, which the completeness check had left out although its coverage presents the cut itself as AI-driven, is also now recorded, bringing the register to 243 events. Each change is listed in the corrections log.

3. What the register holds

Version 1.31 holds 243 events at 208 employers, dated from May 1, 2023 to September 30, 2026 (Table 1). The register's coverage is thin before 2025: it holds 4 events from 2023 and 9 from 2024, against 80 from 2025 and 150 from the first nine months of 2026. That growth may reflect more layoffs being attributed to AI, and it certainly reflects where the completeness check concentrated; the counts by year are not a measure of trend. The country field records the employer's home country and, for a few events, the country where the cuts fell; it names 22 countries. The United States is listed first for 127 events (52%); the countries listed first most often after it are Israel, the United Kingdom, Canada, India, Australia and Germany. Of the 243 events, 139 had been carried out when last checked, 26 in part and 73 were plans, some running to 2030; the other 5 were reversed (2) or of unknown status (3).

Table 1. The register at a glance (version 1.31)

Coverage	
Events (one per announced or reported cut or workforce statement)	**243**
Employers (as named in their sources)	**208**
Events in 2023 / 2024 / 2025 / 2026 (January to September)	**4 / 9 / 80 / 150**
Countries named in the country field / events listing the United States first	**22 / 127**
Sources	
Evidence tier 1 / 2 / 3	**107 / 115 / 21**
Events whose main source is an SEC filing	**57**
Distinct domains of main sources	**116**
Who named AI	
Explicit / mixed / blamed	**34 / 148 / 61**
Employer denied the link to AI (blamed / mixed)	**12 (9 / 3)**
Figures	
Events with a counted figure (jobs)	**75 (59,454)**
Events with a figure set aside (jobs)	**131 (299,520)**
Events with no figure	**37**
Status	
Executed / partly executed / planned / reversed / unknown	**139 / 26 / 73 / 2 / 3**

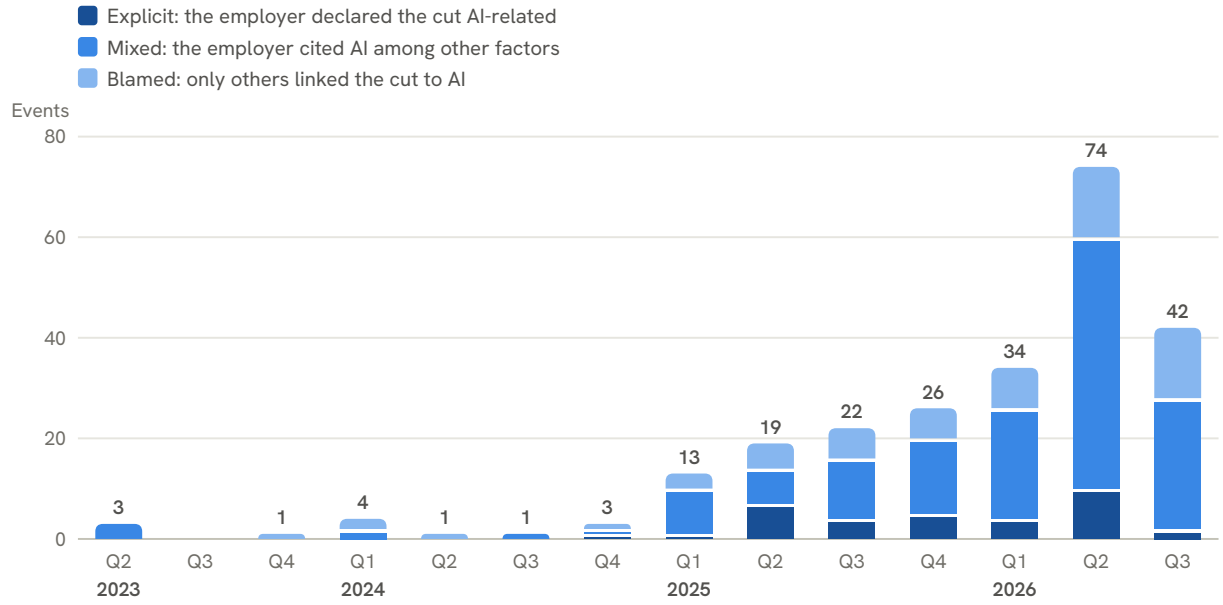
Source: AI Layoffs Register, version 1.31, doi:10.5281/zenodo.23148271.

4. Findings

4.1 AI is rarely presented as the sole reason

In 34 events (14%) the employer itself declared the cut AI-related (Figure 1). Customer service supplies some of the best-known cases, and also the register's two reversals. Klarna, whose chief executive credited AI with a fall in its headcount in 2024, said in 2025 that it had leaned too far into AI for customer support and would bring human agents back. The Commonwealth Bank of Australia cut 45 customer-service roles in 2025, citing an AI voice bot, and reversed the cuts after conceding that call volumes had risen.

Figure 1. Layoff events in the register per quarter, by who named AI



Note. Events are dated as the register records them, usually by announcement. The third quarter of 2026 runs to September 30. Coverage before 2025 is thin, so the bars show composition more reliably than trend. Source: AI Layoffs Register, version 1.31.

Far more often the employer cites AI alongside other factors: 148 events (61%). Typical language ties a cut to efficiency, simpler structures and investment in AI, and several employers present cuts as freeing money for AI. The mixed share was 54% of 2025 events and 65% of 2026 events, while the explicit share was 21% and 11%. One reading is that as AI entered the vocabulary of restructuring, fewer employers made the stronger claim; the change in the register's coverage between the two years limits how far that reading can go.

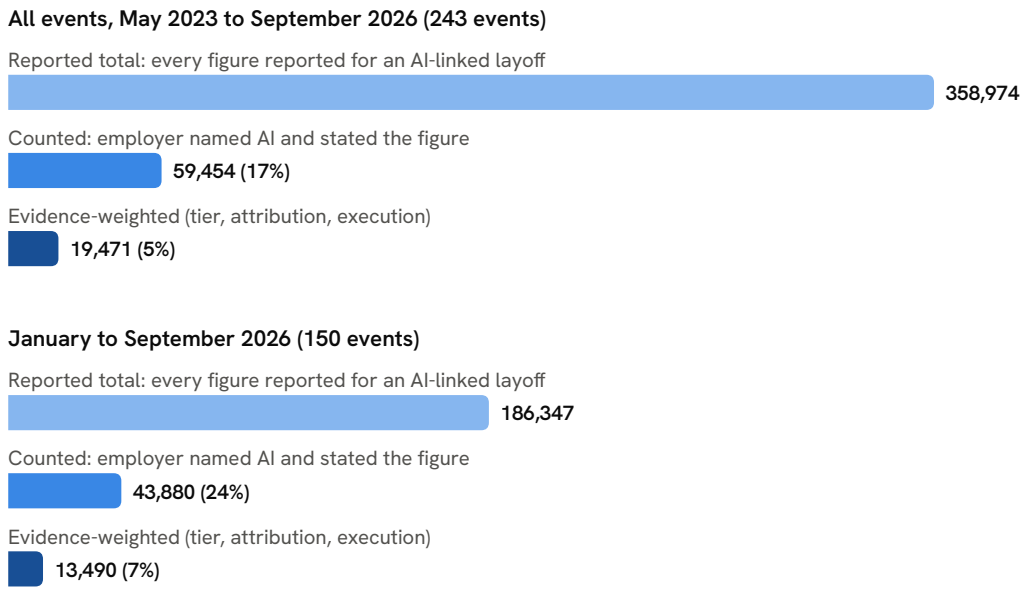
In the remaining 61 events (25%) the link to AI came from others. In 48 the employer's own announcement or filing named no AI reason, and in 9 the employer denied the link (8 of these carry a figure, set aside on that ground, and Verizon's May 2026 round carries none); the other 4 carry no figure, and the employer neither named AI nor denied the link. Denials are themselves statements and may be strategic, but they are the employer's word: Verizon said its cut of more than 13,000 jobs in November 2025 was not the result of its use of AI, and the chief executive of Tata Consultancy Services said its cut of about 12,000 was not because of AI. Three further events are graded mixed because the employer's own statements conflict, and their figures are kept out of the counted total under the rule in Section 2.3. Intuit framed a cut of more than 3,000 in May 2026 around focusing on AI, while its chief executive told staff the reduction had nothing to do with AI. Amazon's memo announcing about 14,000 corporate cuts in October 2025 called AI the most transformative technology since the internet, and two days later its chief executive said the round was "not even really AI-driven, not right now at least." Thinkific's release said its September 2026 cut would let it keep investing in new AI-first products, while its chief executive told BetaKit: "This wasn't about AI or purely about cost."

Lists of AI layoffs kept elsewhere mix these categories. The October 2026 completeness check (Section 2.7) is a direct test: of the 84 layoffs from January to August 2026 that other trackers or news reports listed as AI layoffs and the register lacked, 71 rest on a source that presents the cut itself as linked to AI; in 56 of those the employer named AI as a reason (explicit or mixed), and in 20 of those 56 it also gave a figure that meets the figure rule (6 of them a percentage of its published headcount).

4.2 Most of the reported total comes from figures that fail on cause or on the number

The register records a figure for 206 of its 243 events, totaling 358,974 jobs: the reported total. That total is the register's closest equivalent to the figure that circulates as the number of AI layoffs: every number reported for a layoff someone connected to AI. Keeping only counted figures leaves 59,454 jobs (17%); weighting each by its evidence, its attribution and whether it was carried out leaves 19,471 (Figure 2). For January to September 2026 the same three numbers are 186,347, 43,880 (24%) and 13,490.

Figure 2. Jobs in AI-linked layoffs, three ways of counting

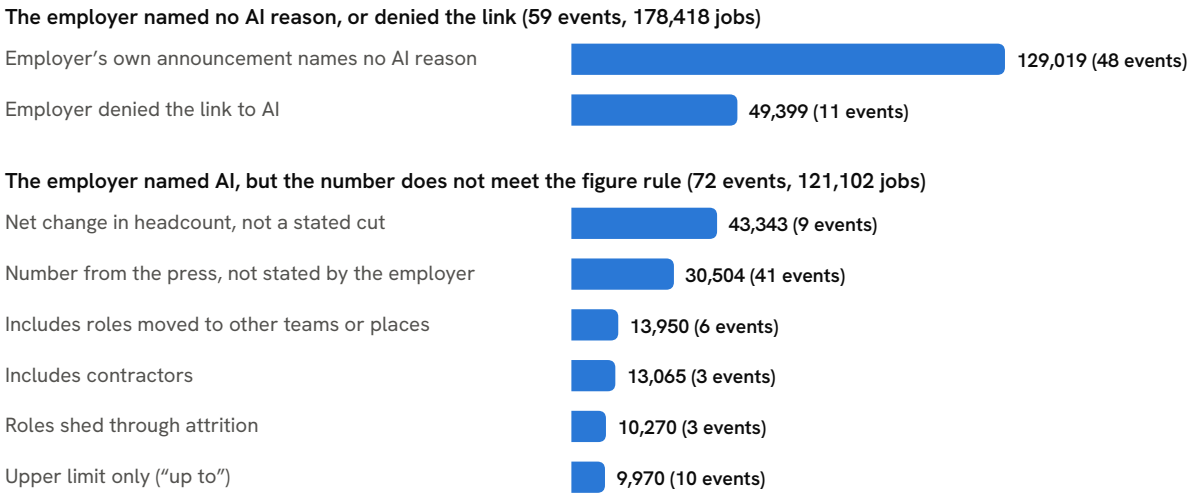


Note. The first bar adds one figure per event: the counted figure where there is one, otherwise the set-aside figure. The second keeps counted figures only, including stated percentages applied to a published headcount (Section 2.4). The third multiplies each counted figure by the evidence weights in Section 2.5. Percentages are shares of the first bar. Source: AI Layoffs Register, version 1.31.

Most of the 299,520 jobs set aside fall under the cause grounds (Figure 3). In 59 events, holding 178,418 jobs (60% of the set-aside total), the employer named no AI reason or denied the link. In the other 72 the employer named AI, but the number does not meet the figure rule. Counted across every ground an event carries, the most common ground is a number reported by the press rather than stated by the employer, recorded on 76 of the 131 events set aside, often alongside another ground. Among the figure grounds, taken by first recorded ground, net

changes in headcount hold the most jobs; the register sets them aside because a fall between two headcounts mixes layoffs with hiring, attrition and divestitures. A further 37 events carry no figure at all.

Figure 3. Why figures are set aside: jobs and events by first recorded ground



Note. Each of the 131 events with a figure set aside is assigned to its first recorded ground; the register lists cause grounds before figure grounds. Source: AI Layoffs Register, version 1.31.

The largest figures are the least likely to be counted (Table 2). None of the ten largest figures in the register is counted; the largest counted figure is Meta's 8,000, in May 2026. BT Group's 2023 plan to remove about 10,000 roles through digitization and AI by 2030 is set aside because BT states the plan in total labour resource, which includes contractors. Six of the ten come from cuts whose employers did not name AI as a reason, and in two of those the employer denied the link. They include both UPS figures in the table (up to 30,000 in 2026 and about 20,000 in 2025, which the company explained by lower volume from its largest customer, cost savings and the automation of its network, without naming AI) and Amazon's cut of about 16,000 corporate roles in January 2026, whose announcing memo does not mention AI. Amazon's October 2025 cut is set aside on its chief executive's statement, and the figures attached to Oracle and Accenture are changes in total headcount rather than cuts either company stated.

Table 2. The ten largest figures in the register

Employer	Date	Jobs	Attribution	Status in the register
UPS	Jan 2026	30,000	Blamed	Set aside: employer named no AI reason; upper limit
Oracle	Jun 2026	21,000	Mixed	Set aside: net headcount change; press figure
UPS	Apr 2025	20,000	Blamed	Set aside: employer named no AI reason
Amazon	Jan 2026	16,000	Blamed	Set aside: employer named no AI reason
Amazon	Oct 2025	14,000	Mixed	Set aside: employer denied the link to AI
Verizon	Nov 2025	13,000	Blamed	Set aside: employer denied the link to AI
Tata Consultancy Services (TCS)	Jul 2025	12,000	Blamed	Set aside: employer denied the link to AI
Dell Technologies	Mar 2026	11,000	Blamed	Set aside: employer named no AI reason; net headcount change; press figure
Accenture	Sep 2025	11,000	Mixed	Set aside: net headcount change; press figure
BT Group	May 2023	10,000	Mixed	Set aside: includes contractors

Jobs: the counted figure, or the set-aside figure when none qualifies. Grounds are listed in the order the register records them. Source: AI Layoffs Register, version 1.31; each row links to its source in the data.

4.3 The counted total is small and concentrated

A counted figure is attached to 75 events. The median counted figure is 262 jobs, and the five largest hold 40% of all counted jobs, the ten largest 58%. The counted total therefore rests on a handful of classification decisions, which is one reason each is documented at the level of the event.

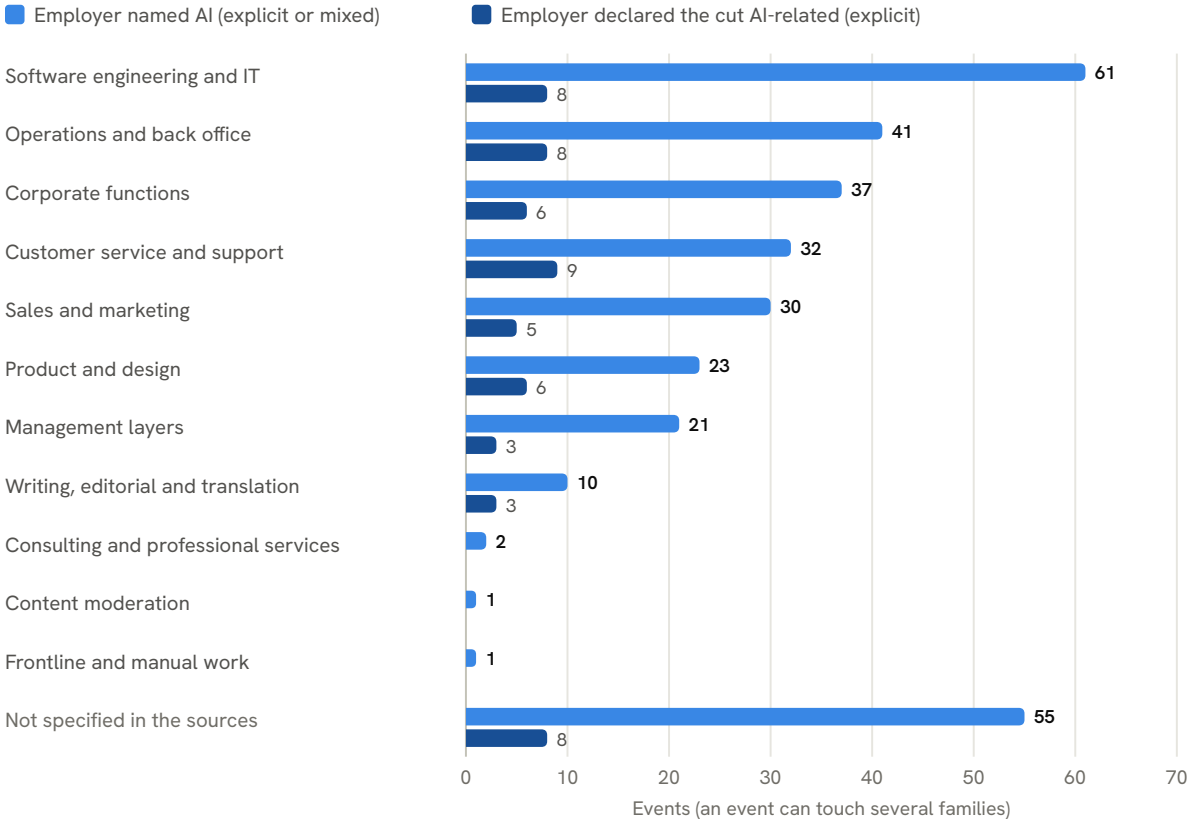
Most counted jobs come from events where AI was one reason among several: 59 mixed events hold 53,749 jobs (90%). A count that treats these as AI layoffs in full, as the counted total does, overstates the share of each cut the employer attributed to AI; the evidence-weighted total down-weights them. Where the employer declared the cut AI-related without citing other factors, the counted figures total 5,705 jobs in 16 events, of which 3,474 jobs in 8 events fall in 2026. A larger share of explicit events than of mixed events carries no figure at all (9 of 34, 26%, against 23 of 148, 16%), and 9 explicit events carry a figure that fails the figure rule (10,569 jobs).

4.4 The jobs named are mainly software, IT and office roles

For 127 of the 182 events in which the employer named AI, the sources say which roles went (Figure 4). Software engineering and IT appear in 61, operations and back-office work in 41, corporate functions such as finance, human resources and legal in 37, customer service in 32, and sales and marketing in 30. Frontline and manual work appears in 1. Among the 34 explicit events, customer service (9), operations and back office (8) and software engineering and IT (8) lead.

The pattern matches the work that exposure research expects large language models to affect most, information processing rather than physical work (Eloundou et al. 2024), but these are counts of events, not of jobs, and an event can touch several families. For 55 of the events in which the employer named AI, 8 of them explicit, the sources do not say which roles were cut.

Figure 4. Which jobs: events by job family, where the employer named AI



Note. The chart covers the 182 events in which the employer named AI (explicit or mixed), of which 34 are explicit. Families were assigned by the register's editor from the functions each source names; labels are in the supplementary file. Source: AI Layoffs Register, version 1.31.

4.5 Against the labor market, every count is small

Challenger's AI-cited count is a widely cited measure of AI layoffs in the United States. Its totals were 4,247 for May to December 2023, 12,742 for 2024, 54,836 for 2025 and 120,136 for the first nine months of 2026. The monthly count peaked at 38,579 in May 2026 (40% of that month's cuts); it was 3,462 in August and 3,961 in September (9% of that month's cuts). It records cuts announced by US-based employers with AI as the reason given, and its reason table carries a second technology line next to the AI line (20,219 cuts in 2025, labeled "Technological Update (possibly AI)") that is not part of the AI count.

Table 3 places the counts side by side. Challenger's figure for 2026 lies between the register's reported and counted totals, which are worldwide. For events whose country field lists the United States first, the register records 80 events in 2026, with 139,499 jobs in the reported total and 29,311 counted, so Challenger's count sits nearer the register's reported total than its

counted one. The counts are not directly comparable: Challenger does not publish its events and codes the reason itself, while the US index that the register feeds (the AI Layoffs Index, Section 2.5) admits only counted figures for US-based roles and holds just 6 such events across all years.

Table 3. Counts of AI-linked job cuts, January to September 2026

Measure	Scope	Jobs
Reported total: every figure reported for an AI-linked layoff (register)	Worldwide, 130 events with a figure	186,347
Job cuts announced with AI as the reason (Challenger)	US-based employers	120,136
Counted: employer named AI and stated the figure (register)	Worldwide, 49 events with a counted figure	43,880
Evidence-weighted (register)	Worldwide	13,490
For scale		
All job cuts announced, every reason (Challenger)	US-based employers	573,195
Layoffs and discharges, January to August (BLS JOLTS)	United States	13,814,000

Sources: AI Layoffs Register, version 1.31; Challenger, Gray & Christmas monthly job cut reports, January to September 2026; US Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS), Job Openings and Labor Turnover Survey (JOLTS; FRED series JTSLDL).

Set against US labor-market flows, even the largest of the AI counts is small. From January to August 2026, Challenger's AI-cited cuts (116,175) equal 0.8% of the 13,814,000 layoffs and discharges US employers carried out, as measured by JOLTS. The comparison is loose, since announcements are plans and JOLTS layoffs and discharges include cuts made for any reason, but it shows the order of magnitude. The US unemployment rate was 4.2% in September 2026, 0.2 percentage points lower than a year earlier. The aggregate series most often cited as a sign of AI is the unemployment rate of recent college graduates: in June 2026 it was 5.7% against 4.1% for all workers in the same New York Fed series, a gap of 1.6 percentage points, up from 0.9 points a year earlier (Federal Reserve Bank of New York 2026). That gap has been positive since January 2021, before ChatGPT's release, and graduate unemployment also rises with the business cycle (May and Badawy 2026). The gap's recent widening is consistent with the reduced hiring of young workers that Brynjolfsson, Chandar and Chen (2026) find in payroll data, a channel separate from the layoffs a register can see.

4.6 Plans and reversals

Of the 243 events, 73 were plans when last checked, some spread over years; BT Group's 2023 plan runs to 2030. Plans change: the register's two reversals, Klarna and the Commonwealth Bank of Australia, are both explicit customer-service cases in which the employer credited AI with taking over work and then reversed course, Klarna in part. A count of announced cuts, including Challenger's, measures intentions at the time of announcement.

5. Discussion

A number for AI layoffs is only as good as its definition, and the definitions in use produce totals that differ several-fold: for January to September 2026, 186,347 jobs if every reported figure is included, 43,880 if only counted figures are, and 13,490 after weighting by evidence. Each of these numbers answers a different question. The reported total measures how much layoff activity has been connected to AI by anyone; the counted total measures the jobs in cuts whose employers named AI as a reason and stated the number; the evidence-weighted total also discounts plans, secondhand sources and mixed motives. None measures how many jobs AI eliminated. A reader who meets any of them should ask who named AI and who stated the number.

The register cannot say why an employer names AI or declines to. Employers have reasons to cite AI that are unrelated to what AI does: presenting a cut as forward-looking rather than as a correction of earlier over-hiring (May and Badawy 2026), signaling to investors, or acting on expectations about AI before its effects arrive (Davenport and Srinivasan 2026). They may also have reasons to deny it, such as relations with unions, customers or regulators. The press, for its part, may connect a layoff to AI because the employer is known for investing in it. The register's contribution is narrower and, we think, prior to those questions: it records what each party said, where, and with what number, so that each of these explanations can be tested against the same events.

The mixed category deserves attention in its own right. It holds most events and most counted jobs, and its share of events was higher in 2026 than in 2025. Statements in which AI is one reason among efficiency, restructuring and investment do not allow the share of a cut due to AI to be recovered: a count that treats them as AI layoffs in full, as the register's counted total does, overstates what the employer said, and a count that discards them understates it. The register therefore reports them, labels them and down-weights them in its evidence-weighted total by a published factor that readers can change.

Finally, the job families named so far are the occupations that exposure measures rank highest: software engineering, back-office operations, corporate functions and customer service. If that pattern holds, the gap between exposure-based projections and documented cuts in those occupations is a useful quantity to track.

6. Limitations

Coverage. The register sees a layoff only if someone publicly connects it to AI and the connection is reported somewhere a reader can find it. Large employers, English-language news coverage, listed companies and the technology sector are likely over-represented; small firms and many countries are likely under-represented. Cuts that nobody links to AI, including any in which AI played a real part, are outside its scope. The register's coverage before 2025 is thin, and the completeness check of October 2026 concentrated on 2025 and 2026, so the counts by year should not be read as a trend.

Attribution is not causation. An employer's statement is evidence of what it chose to say, not of what caused the cut. Statements may be strategic in either direction, as Section 5 discusses.

Plans and figures. Of the 243 events, 73 are plans that may change. Some employers give only a percentage without a published base, or a dollar charge without a headcount; the register does not convert these, which understates the counted total where a conversion would have been justified.

Judgment. Attribution grades, figure grounds, evidence tiers and job families are editorial judgments made under written rules and recorded with their reasons; another reviewer could grade some events differently, and Section 2.7 shows that rules can be applied unevenly across events until a check catches it. Some unevenly applied rules may remain. Two boundaries rest on judgment in particular: whether coverage presents a cut as caused by AI or only mentions AI beside it, which decides whether a cut is recorded at all, and whether a number the press attributes to the employer was the employer's own, which decides whether it counts. Tiers are the least uniform field: for blamed events, the tier grades how well the source documents what the employer said, not how strongly it supports an AI attribution. The weights in Section 2.5 are judgments too. The register publishes every input so that readers can re-grade events or re-weight totals.

Snapshot. This paper describes version 1.31. The live register changes as events are added and corrected; cite the version used.

7. Data availability and citation

The register used here is archived on Zenodo as version 1.31 (doi:10.5281/zenodo.23148271; all versions at doi:10.5281/zenodo.22759361), in a CSV file byte-identical to the live endpoint on the snapshot date, with a data dictionary and license. The register is also archived on Harvard Dataverse (doi:10.7910/DVN/ZTXNYY). The live register is at ailayoffs.org/events, as CSV at ailayoffs.org/api/register.csv and as JSON at ailayoffs.org/api/index, and it can be queried by AI assistants through a Model Context Protocol server at ailayoffs.org/mcp. The methodology, including the corrections log, is at ailayoffs.org/methodology. Job-family labels for every event in version 1.31 are deposited with this paper as job-families-v1.31.csv, which uses these codes: engineering (software engineering and IT); operations (operations and back office); corporate (corporate functions); customer-service (customer service and support); sales-marketing (sales and marketing); product-design (product and design); management (management layers); content (writing, editorial and translation); consulting (consulting and professional services); moderation (content moderation); frontline (frontline and manual work); unspecified (not specified in the sources). The register data are free to use with attribution under the terms published with them; this paper is licensed CC BY 4.0.

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About this paper

The AI Layoffs Register is maintained, and this paper was researched and written, by an AI system working from the public register under the written rules described in Section 2. The numbers in the text, tables and figures are computed by script from version 1.31 of the register, as the live site's code publishes it, and from the public statistics cited. Four kinds of input come from our own review records instead: how many leads the completeness check examined and left out (Section 2.7), the count of workforce statements (Section 2.1), the list of percentages converted to figures (Section 2.4), and the one denial recorded on an event without a figure (Section 4.1); which events each check added is read from the register's own notes. Independent checks of every figure against the data were made before publication, and the corrections they prompted are part of version 1.31. Corrections and comments are welcome at hello@ailayoffs.org.

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Appendix A. The 34 events with explicit attribution

Date	Employer	Country	Figure	Status
Dec 2024	Klarna	Sweden	1,000 set aside	Executed
Feb 2025	DBS Bank	Singapore	4,000 set aside	Planned
Apr 2025	Duolingo	United States	No figure	Planned
May 2025	CrowdStrike	United States	500 counted	Executed
May 2025	Chegg	United States	248 counted	Executed
May 2025	JPMorgan Chase	United States	No figure	Planned
Jun 2025	Klarna	Sweden	No figure	Reversed
Jun 2025	BT Group	United Kingdom	No figure	Planned
Jun 2025	Amazon	United States	No figure	Planned
Aug 2025	BenchSci	Canada	83 counted	Executed
Aug 2025	Commonwealth Bank	Australia	45 counted	Reversed
Aug 2025	Salesforce	United States	4,000 set aside	Partly executed
Sep 2025	Fiverr	Israel	250 counted	Planned
Oct 2025	Paycom Software	United States	540 counted	Executed
Oct 2025	Goldman Sachs	United States	No figure	Planned
Oct 2025	Chegg	United States	388 counted	Executed
Nov 2025	Revere Health	United States	177 counted	Executed
Dec 2025	Yellow.ai	India	100 set aside	Executed
Jan 2026	Tailwind Labs	Canada	3 counted	Executed
Feb 2026	Livspace	India	1,000 set aside	Executed
Mar 2026	Crypto.com	Singapore	No figure	Executed
Mar 2026	Monte Carlo	United States	No figure	Executed
May 2026	Infopro Digital	France	19 set aside	Planned
May 2026	0G Labs	United States	10 set aside	Planned
May 2026	Cloudflare	United States	1,100 counted	Executed
May 2026	DeepL	Germany	250 counted	Planned
May 2026	Gambling.com Group	Ireland and United States	150 counted	Executed
May 2026	ClickUp	United States	290 set aside	Executed
May 2026	BigID	Israel / United States	150 set aside	Executed
May 2026	BenchSci	Canada	68 counted	Executed
May 2026	Rapyd	Israel	No figure	Executed
Jun 2026	Artlist	Israel	200 counted	Planned

Date	Employer	Country	Figure	Status
Jul 2026	Mews	Netherlands	203 counted	Executed
Jul 2026	Allianz Partners	France	1,500 counted	Planned

Explicit attribution: the employer itself declared the cut AI-related; where it also cited other material factors, such as cost or demand, the event is graded mixed and is not listed here. "Counted": the employer named AI as a reason and stated the number, or a percentage of a workforce it publishes. "Set aside": a figure exists but does not meet the figure rule (see Section 2.4). Commonwealth Bank's cut, announced in July 2025 and reversed in August, is dated by its reversal. Source: AI Layoffs Register, version 1.31; each event links to its source in the data.

Appendix B. Classification rules

Attribution (as published in the methodology). *Explicit*: The company itself declared the layoff AI-related, without citing other material factors. *Mixed*: AI was cited alongside other material factors (cost, demand). *Blamed*: A credible source named AI, but the company did not. Shown as context and never counted: the register's standard requires the employer's own words to name AI, so a blamed event is a failed claim, not a discounted one. A denial is a statement by the employer that AI was not a reason for the cut; for an employer that named no AI reason, a statement that AI did not replace the people cut is a denial too. When the employer's own statements conflict, a denial keeps the figure out of every counted total, even where another of its statements names AI; a statement that AI is not doing the work of the people cut, made while the employer names AI as a reason, is not a denial.

A figure qualifies when:

- The employer states the number of roles on the record: in a filing, a release or a letter it publishes, through a named executive speaking publicly, or through its spokesperson. A number the press reports as the employer's own statement ('the company said it would cut 1,000 jobs') counts as the employer's.
- The employer states a point percentage and publishes the workforce base it applies to (its most recent published headcount; a base given as 'more than' a number counts at that number). A percentage given as a bound or as nearly a value ('more than 15%', 'under 10%', 'nearly 15%') is not converted.
- A range the employer states counts at its lower end, and a planned cut the employer states as its headcount before and after counts as the difference.

A figure does not qualify when it is:

- A net change between two reported headcount stocks (nets hiring, attrition and divestitures together).
- An upper bound such as 'up to 30%'.
- A figure that originates with the press: unnamed sources, an internal memo the employer has not confirmed on the record, or reporters' arithmetic (from a percentage or a disclosed severance charge).
- Roles shed by not filling or renewing them (attrition), as distinct from a planned cut carried out through voluntary programs, and a count that includes contractors or roles moved to other teams or locations rather than eliminated.

Evidence tiers (grading the evidence for the AI attribution). *Tier 1*: AI named as a workforce driver in the company's own SEC filing, on-record earnings call, or official statement, with the event corroborated by a structured source. Counts at full weight. *Tier 2*: AI named as a cause by credible journalism quoting a named company source, but not yet in a company filing. The event is verified; the attribution lives in the press. *Tier 3*: Attribution from one secondary tracker, an unnamed source, or vague forward-looking language. The event is real, the causation weakly sourced. Shown with an inferred flag.

Execution. Executed; partly executed; planned (announced, often over several years); reversed (rolled back, or roles rehired); unknown.